

Many soil organisms decompose (break down) plant matter. Living plants feed on the broken-down material, so dead things don't pile up on the ground!

What looks like white fur on a leaf is fungi.



4 smaller and smaller

Microbes (tiny living things) such as fungi wrap around leaf fragments.

Microbes release chemicals to decompose the fragments even further.

Decomposed plants keep soil fertile for things to grow.

Nutrients are taken in as the food passes through.

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Worm poo

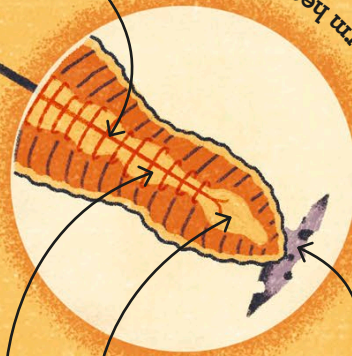
Decomposing leaves are eaten and digested by earthworms. Worm casts (poo) are mixed into the soil.

Microorganisms such as bacteria feed on worm casts and release nutrients for plants.

Food is stored here for a short while.

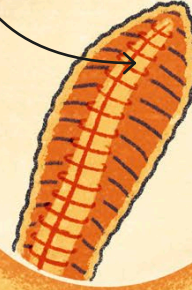
Previously eaten stones help grind up food.

Powerful lips suck in food.



Earthworm head

Casts pass out the other end.



Earthworm tail